There are historical records of references to local self government under Mauryan administration. Local self government existed throughout the country with its own diverse characteristics of ancient India. During the medieval period, local self governments had somewhat declined due to the onslaught of feudalism. It was revived during the British period in the last quarter of the 19th century, with Western orientation of training in democracy with Lord Ripon's Resolution in 1882. Lord Ripon was known as the 'Father of Local Government for laying the foundations of local self governments in modern times.

Under the Government of India Act, 1935 provincial autonomy was introduced. This Act came into force in 1937. In the provinces where the Congress formed its Government, rural development received special attention. It was an essential part of Gandhi's programme that Panchayat Raj institutions would be built from villages to the highest level.

After Independence, the Gandhian ideal of Grama Swaraj (Village Republic) greatly influenced the constitution makers. India being the land of villages, the creation of village panchayats became a social movement. Restoration of panchayats has become an article of faith during our freedom struggle.

Lord Ripon

Lord Ripon was the one who gave Indians the first taste of freedom by introducing the Local Self Government in 1882.

Ripon took some steps towards liberalizing the administration in India. He formulated the local self government and made it clear that he was advocating for the decentralization of administration.



Lord Ripon

He tried to remove obstacles in the sphere of Local Self government by his resolution of 1882. He led a series of enactments in which larger powers of the local self-government were given to the rural and urban bodies and the elected people received wider rights.

5.3 Local Self Governments since Independence

The conceptualisation of the system of local self-government in India took place through the formation and effort of four important committees from the year 1957 to 1986. The Community Development Programme (1952) and National Extension Service (1953) became a basis for 'The Great Charter on Panchayat Raj' in 1957. The panchayatraj system was inagurated on October 2, in nugaur district of Rajasthan by the then Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru.

Salient Features of the 73rd and 74th Constitution Amendment Acts (1992)

- Panchayats and Municipalities will be 'institutions of self-government'.
- Grama Sabhas (Villages) and Ward Committees (Municipalities) comprising .
- Three-tier system of panchayats at village, taluk and district levels.
- Seats at all levels filled by direct elections.
- Seats reserved for chairpersons of the Panchayats at all levels also shall

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